

MEDLARS AND QUINCES

Mespilus germanica and *Cydonia oblonga*

These unusual tree fruits look highly ornamental, and are an acquired taste, but are well worth growing if you have the space. Rose-hiplike medlars (see below) should be left until sweet-tasting and almost rotten before eating. Quinces (see right) are rarely soft enough to eat if grown in a cool climate, but are delicious cooked or used in jams or jellies.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
PLANT				
HARVEST				

PLANTING

As with all trees, ensure that container-grown medlars and quinces have not become pot-bound. Plant bare-root trees between late winter and early spring. You can plant container-grown trees at any time, but fall is preferred. Medlars and quinces are best planted in a warm, sheltered site and in well-drained soil; both are self-fertile, so will not need another tree to produce fruit. Dig well-rotted manure or compost into the soil a few months before planting.

CROP CARE

Young trees will need to be staked for the first few years. Quinces appreciate regular



Leave medlars to “blet” before eating.

feeding and watering, especially during spring and summer if the weather is dry. Medlars need feeding and watering while young, but after a few years will cope without any extra watering. Mulch well around young trees with compost, manure, or bark chips. Quinces and medlars will be largely untroubled by frost, provided they have been sited correctly.